# SOVEREIGN CITY

## FOUNDER MODE · OFFICIAL RULEBOOK

Version 3 · Ruleset 2.0 · 2 to 6 founders · Ages 13+ · 45 to 60 minutes

*Junior rules (ages 8 to 12) are on their own sheet. Same cards, simpler game.*

## THE IDEA

You are a founder in Sovereign City. You start with $5,000, a problem worth solving, and two actions a round. You will pitch neighbors, hire help, automate, buy equity-free credibility with a mural, and decide which investor money is worth which slice of your company.

The goal is not to be rich. The goal is Sovereignty: a business that runs three straight profitable rounds without your hands on it, while you spend your turns mentoring the next founder. Build what you own. Then teach someone else to.

## WHAT IS ON THE TABLE

Board (4 tiles, a zone map: there is no movement and there are no pawns) · 12 Industry Cards with Payout Strips on the back · 18 Problem Cards · 24 Pitch Cards · 24-card Market Chaos Deck · 5 Investor Cards · Player Mats · HQ Flip Tiles · overhead chips · money · Customer Tokens · Mural Tokens · the Goose · Sovereignty Towers · 2 dice.

## SETUP

1. Take $5,000, a Player Mat, an HQ Tile set to VACANT, your chip row, and set your Cap Table clip on 100%.
2. Draw 3 Problem Cards, keep 1. This is the problem your business solves.
3. Pick any Industry Card and slide it into your mat, Payout Strip face up. If your industry is a Strong Match printed on your Problem Card, take 1 free Customer Token. Any pairing is legal.
4. Name your business and write it on the mat. Non-negotiable. The name goes on the tower.
5. Shuffle the Pitch Cards and the Market Chaos Deck (Chaos starts on Round 3). Lay the 5 Investor Cards face-up on Investor Row. Trust Pool bowl in the center of the board.

## THE 12 INDUSTRIES

*Tier A is easy to pitch with small payouts. Tier C is hard to pitch with big payouts. The Tier modifier is added to every pitch target.*

| Industry | Base | Boom | Tier | Perk |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Music & Sound | $20 | $25 | A (+0) | Busk at City Market: 1 action, roll 1d6, collect x $10. On 5-6 also gain 1 customer. |
| Food & Drink | $20 | $25 | A (+0) | City Festival: collect the Festival column AND the Normal column. |
| Local Services | $25 | $30 | A (+0) | Ignore the first BigCorp Attacks card each game. |
| Sports & Fitness | $25 | $30 | A (+0) | School Partnership card: gain 2 customers instead of 1. |
| Acting & Film | $25 | $30 | B (+1) | Viral Moment: gain 4 Customer Tokens instead of 3. |
| Fashion & Merch | $30 | $40 | B (+1) | Viral Moment: gain 4 Customer Tokens instead of 3. |
| Education | $30 | $40 | B (+1) | School Partnership card: gain 2 customers instead of 1. |

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|---|---|---|---|---|
| Arts & Design | $30 | $40 | B (+1) | Viral Moment: gain 4 Customer Tokens instead of 3. |
| Tech & Apps | $35 | $45 | C (+2) | Automation costs $3,500 instead of $5,000. |
| Agency & Talent | $45 | $55 | C (+2) | Networking Night card: gain 2 customers instead of 1. |
| AI Studio | $50 | $65 | C (+2) | Automation costs $3,000, cheapest in the city. |
| Infrastructure | $60 | $80 | C (+2) | Double share when Sovereign District Scores fires. |

## EVERY ROUND • 4 PHASES

### 1 • MARKET CHAOS (Rounds 3+)

Draw 1 card, read aloud, apply immediately. Column shifts last one round unless the card says otherwise.

### 2 • ACTIONS

Each founder takes 2 actions in turn order: Pitch, Upgrade HQ, Hire, Automate, Buy a Mural, Pitch an Investor, or Mentor. The same action may be taken twice.

### 3 • SETTLE

Everyone at once: count your Customer Tokens, add 1 row per Employee chip, and read your active column on your Payout Strip. Collect that amount from the bank. Rows 13-15 require an Automated HQ. Food founders on Festival collect the Festival column AND the Normal column. On any Boom or Festival, every founder puts $20 in the Community Trust Pool.

### 4 • OVERHEAD

Everyone at once: pay the bank the total of your chips. If you cannot pay, see Bankruptcy. If you have declared a Sovereignty Run and this round's Settle exceeded your Overhead, check one box on your tracker.

## THE ACTIONS

### PITCH A CUSTOMER

Draw a Pitch Card. Choose ONE approach: Problem, Price, or Persona. Add your Tier modifier to the target. Roll 2d6. Meet or beat it: take 1 Customer Token (some cards give 2). Miss: discard.

**THE MERCY RULE: miss but roll doubles and the customer joins anyway. A referral you did not see coming. This is Locked Ruling 1 and it is absolute.**

### HUSTLE MILESTONES

At 5, 10, and 15 customers, take a Milestone card: a permanent +1 to ONE pitch approach of your choice. Stack them or spread them.

### UPGRADE HQ • $1,500

Flip your tile from VACANT to HQ and add the $50 Rent chip ($30 automated). An HQ unlocks hiring.

### HIRE AN EMPLOYEE • $120 • max 3

Add an Employee chip: $60 per round manual, $40 automated. Each Employee lets you read your Payout Strip 1 row higher at Settle. Three employees at 9 customers reads row 12. Zero math, real payroll: an employee pays for themselves in a Tier C business and barely breaks even in Tier A. That is the lesson.

### AUTOMATE · at the Tech Hub

Pay the lump sum printed at the Tech Hub: AI Studio $3,000, Tech & Apps $3,500, everyone else $5,000. Flip your tile to AUTOMATED and swap every chip to its AUTO value (about 40% cheaper). Your customer cap rises from 12 to 15 and strip rows 13-15 unlock.

### BUY A MURAL · $2,000 · at the Sovereign District

Take your Mural Token. Your home column becomes BOOM, permanently. $1,000 of the price goes into the Community Trust Pool. The mural also shields you: BigCorp Attacks cannot touch you, and during a Recession you land on Normal while everyone else falls.

### PITCH AN INVESTOR

Meet the requirement on the card, then roll 7+ on 2d6 to close. Collect the cash and slide your Cap Table clip. A miss stays face-up: they remember, and a retry costs a full turn.

### MENTOR

Give any other founder 1 free action right now. Sovereign Fund founders must Mentor at least once before declaring a Sovereignty Run. During a Run, Mentor replaces BOTH of your actions: your only move is lifting someone else.

## MONEY · THE PAYOUT STRIP

Your strip has four columns: RECESSION, NORMAL, BOOM, FESTIVAL. Your home column is NORMAL, or BOOM if you hold a Mural Token. Chaos shifts you: Recession 1 left, Market Boom 1 right, City Festival 2 right. Shifts are net and stop at the strip edges. Find your customer count row (plus Employee rows), read your column, collect. No arithmetic at the table, ever.

## THE COMMUNITY TRUST POOL

$20 in from every founder on every Boom or Festival. $1,000 in from every mural. When Sovereign District Scores is drawn, the pool splits evenly among Mural holders, rounded UP to the nearest $5 (Infrastructure takes a double share). Empty pool: $100 per holder from the bank. Wealth that circulates beats wealth that sits.

## THE INVESTORS

| Investor | Requirement | Cash | Equity |
|---|---|---|---|
| David Park · Angel | 8+ customers AND revenue above overhead last round | $10,000 | 15% to Park |
| David Park · 2nd Look | A failed Investor card face-up + 10+ customers | $15,000 | 15% to Park |
| Victoria Chase · VC | Automated HQ AND 15+ customers | $50,000 | 20% to Chase |
| Victoria Chase · Conviction | Automated HQ AND a Mural Token | $100,000 | 25% to Chase |
| Sovereign Fund · Community | Mural Token + 1 Mentor Action before your Run | $8,000 | 5%, best terms in the city |

*The quiet math: a mural costs $2,000 and the Sovereign Fund hands back $8,000 at 5%. The community route funds your General Manager exactly, and you keep 95% of everything. Nobody at the table will point this out. The player who notices wins differently.*

Cap table floor: you can never sell past 49% total. A deal that would cross the floor cannot close. Locked Ruling 2.

## SOVEREIGNTY · HOW YOU WIN

- Hire your General Manager for $8,000 (overhead $250, or $150 automated). The GM makes your business capable of running without you.
- Declare your Sovereignty Run at the start of any round.
- For 3 straight rounds: your Settle must exceed your Overhead, and your only action each round is MENTOR. A loss round resets all three boxes.
- Three checks: SOVEREIGNTY. Place your tower on the Skyline. Record your founder name, business name, and final cash in the Hall of Fame.

Tiebreaker: if two founders complete Sovereignty in the same round, most cash on hand wins. At game end, investors collect their equity percentage of your final cash, and every founder records final cash in the Hall of Fame. Equity you sold follows you all the way to the last line.

## BANKRUPTCY

Cannot pay Overhead? Your business closes, but you do not leave the table. Take the Comeback Loan: $1,500, once per game, re-enter next round with your Industry Card. The Comeback Story chaos card re-enters a bankrupt founder free. Failure is a chapter, not an ending. Locked Ruling 6.

## LOCKED RULINGS

*These settle every table dispute. They are printed on the box lid sheet as well.*

**1 · DOUBLES ARE ABSOLUTE**

Fail a pitch but roll doubles? Referral anyway. The customer is yours. No modifier overrides this. No exceptions.

**2 · CAP TABLE FLOOR AT 51%**

Total equity sold can never exceed 49%. A deal that would cross the line cannot close this turn. You always control your company.

**3 · SOVEREIGN FUND GATE**

Took the Fund's money? Take at least 1 Mentor Action before declaring your Sovereignty Run. Wealth means nothing if it never multiplies.

**4 · COLUMN SHIFTS ARE NET AND BOUNDED**

Shifts stack as one net move and stop at the printed strip edges (Recession and Festival). Nothing takes you off the card.

**5 · TRUST POOL ROUNDING**

Split evenly and round every payout UP to the nearest $5. Shortfall from the bank. Empty pool: $100 per Mural holder from the bank.

**6 · BANKRUPTCY IS A CHAPTER**

Nobody sits out. Comeback Loan: $1,500 once per game, re-enter next round. The Comeback Story card re-enters you free.

**7 · HANDS HAVE A CEILING. SYSTEMS DO NOT.**

Manual founders hold at most 12 Customer Tokens and read at most row 12. Automation lifts the cap to 15, unlocks rows 13-15, and cuts overhead about 40%. Employee row bonuses never read past row 15.

*FOUNDER'S NOTE · TIER C EARLY GAME (advice, not a ruling): your Strong Match token is your launchpad, not a bonus. Hunt low targets first: Hype Friend (Persona 6+, your 8+) and Church Director (Problem 6+, your 8+). Claim the free token, close two easy pitches, and you have 3 customers before Round 2 ends. Harder pitch, bigger revenue: that is the Tier C trade.*

## RULESET 2.0 · WHAT CHANGED

- Employees redesigned: each reads your strip +1 row at Settle, $60/$40 overhead. The old revenue multiplier is gone.
- Customer caps defined: manual 12, automated 15. Strips now run 15 rows; rows 13-15 are marked AUTOMATED ONLY.
- The strip column formerly named MURAL is now BOOM. A Mural Token makes BOOM your home column.
- Mentor is a standard action, and Sovereign Fund founders must Mentor once BEFORE declaring a Run.
- Tiebreaker and Hall of Fame final-cash records added. Investors collect equity from final cash.
- Chaos deck gains School Partnership and Networking Night so the Sports, Education, and Agency perks have live triggers, plus one blank House Card.
- Junior Mode rebuilt around a single win: first to 12 customers. See the Junior sheet.
- Board rebuilt as a zone map with all action sites. No movement, no pawns, no dead squares.
- All Payout Strips regenerate from one formula (Recession rounds UP to $5). founder_mode_data.json is the single source of truth.